

owned by their supposedly richer clients. After getting a bill for the renovations on my boathouse, I can see why that's the case.

There's also this dichotomy to consider: According to a 2012 report from the Brookings Institution, 76 percent of available jobs require some form of postsecondary education. But the percentage of jobs that require a *degree* is only 43 percent. (And don't forget that 100 percent of those student loans have to be paid back.) So the chances of finding gainful employment with a diploma instead of a degree are tipped in your favor. Then there's the fact that tradespeople are in increasing demand; the McKinsey Global Institute predicts that employers around the world will need nearly 45 million more medium-skill laborers (workers with secondary school and vocational training) by 2020. This potential disaster is an incredible opportunity for entrepreneurial tradespeople.

In the end, the best thing about the trades is that they're creative. You're working with your hands, you're making and doing something tangible, and you're sometimes working outdoors. If this lifestyle suits you, go for it.

Quiz: Are You Ready for the High Cost of Higher Ed?

Kids, this one's for you. If you're considering postsecondary education, take this quiz first and see if it really is the best next step for your future.

1. In high school, you were the kind of student who:

- a) slept in, skipped classes, and was more interested in your weekend plan than your teacher's lesson plan. You know you're not stupid, even though some of your teachers thought you were. It's just that to be engaged, you need to be doing something hands-on.
- b) did the bare minimum, just enough to get by unnoticed and unchallenged, but loved working part-time jobs in the "real" world, where you learned practical skills and where people you worked with praised your work ethic.